

The Conscious Disease

Mack Thompson

The Song of Creation
The Rig-Veda Nasadiya Sukta, 1500-1200 BCE

Then was not non-existent nor existent: there was no realm of air, no sky beyond it.
What covered in, and where? and what gave shelter? Was water there, unfathomed depth of water?

Death was not then, nor was there aught immortal: no sign was there, the day's and night's divider.

That One Thing, breathless, breathed by its own nature: apart from it was nothing whatsoever.
Darkness there was: at first concealed in darkness this All was indiscriminated chaos.
All that existed then was void and formless: by the great power of warmth was born that unit.

Thereafter rose desire in the beginning, Desire, the primal seed and germ of spirit.
Sages who searched with their heart's thought discovered the existent's kinship in the non-existent.

Transversely was their severing line extended: what was above it then, and what below it?
There were begetters, there were mighty forces, free action here and energy up yonder.
Who verily knows and who can here declare it, whence it was born and whence comes this creation?

The gods are later than this world's production. Who knows, then, whence it first came into being?
He, the first origin of this creation, whether he formed it all or did not form it,
Whose eye controls this world in highest heaven, he verily knows it, or perhaps he knows not.

Tao Te Ching state opening, 400-300 BCE

The Way that can be walked is not the eternal Way.

The name that can be named is not the eternal name.

The nameless is the beginning of Heaven and Earth.

The named is the mother of all things.

Therefore:

Free from desire you see the mystery.

Full of desire you see the manifestations.

These two have the same origin but differ in name.

That is the secret,

The secret of secrets,

The gate to all mysteries.

Genesis 1:1-10, 1200-500 BCE

King James Bible

¹In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth.

² And the earth was without form, and void; and darkness was upon the face of the deep. And the Spirit of God moved upon the face of the waters.

³ And God said, Let there be light: and there was light.

⁴ And God saw the light, that it was good: and God divided the light from the darkness.

⁵ And God called the light Day, and the darkness he called Night. And the evening and the morning were the first day.

⁶ And God said, Let there be a firmament in the midst of the waters, and let it divide the waters from the waters.

⁷ And God made the firmament, and divided the waters which were under the firmament from the waters which were above the firmament: and it was so.

⁸ And God called the firmament Heaven. And the evening and the morning were the second day.

⁹ And God said, Let the waters under the heaven be gathered together unto one place, and let the dry land appear: and it was so.

¹⁰ And God called the dry land Earth; and the gathering together of the waters called he Seas: and God saw that it was good.

Introduction to the Universe

For the last thirty years of his life, Albert Einstein obsessed with his theory that all fundamental forces are the same. He elegantly put, “I want to know God’s thoughts,” believing that discovering a universal equilibrium would expose the means through which God architects. A theory so seductive that it followed him to his deathbed, where he asked only for his glasses, his writing implements, and his latest equations. He believed he was close, and he had set the stage for the next generation to follow. But that mind has yet to emerge, and we are left with an incomplete picture.

Through the eyes of Einstein, everything is predestined, as “God does not play dice.” Our thoughts are products of a billion-year process with nothing in between; life happens to us. Thus, the *conscious disease* spreads: one day, we wake up, and we know ourselves. We remember some time into our past, but not our first day here. And it is so: our internal monologue begins to separate us from the universe. ‘I am me, and no one else is me,’ it says. While this might not be a false statement, the voice cries desperately: ‘No one could describe the depths of me,’ but given more time, maybe Einstein could.

The brain emerged to recognize patterns; a biological machine that could *do* science. And recognizing the shape of reality was deeply troubling. It could watch the circle of life but never allowed to step outside. There was no concept of what death smells like from within. And so, it begs, ‘what does death feel like? Why does death steal life?’ And nobody responds. Without an answer, vastly different hypotheses emerged through the trials of time: some denying death, some embracing it, and some seeing it as the wrong question to ask. Religion became the science of life, facing the fundamental problem of how to live without understanding the beginning or the end. But the religious scientist cannot publish a paper on “the correct faith” because this metric is deeply subjective, and we surely don’t know if any of the claims a religion makes are true. Thus, it remains: how blissfully ignorant should we live our life?

We spend few waking hours contemplating this honestly. The culture we live in shapes our deepest intuition, and our faith follows close behind. It’s comforting and safe. But I believe the longer we remain unsatisfied, the more alive we feel. Of course, this is a slippery slope. Now, I understand why all the best philosophers were depressed. The root of natural philosophy is

nothing, and all experience is relative. We cling to familiar patterns because that is what we were built to do; because there is no value to life without making assumptions. We layer abstraction on abstraction, inventing categories to assign observations. For example, we might assume our universe is built from particles to create a model of chemistry. This model might work extremely well to describe all kinds of behavior. We might even follow this with another, like groups of molecules can form organisms, and organisms can create humans. This is where Einstein saw beauty: what if I could describe the entire universe from a singular assumption about matter?

The purpose of this work is to uncover the neglected assumptions from which our grip on reality is built. It follows three parts: the end of the physical universe, the beginning of the spiritual, and the search for self between the two. The inevitability of intelligent life like ours is compelling when observed from the current physical framework. But just because this story of natural law is compelling, doesn't mean it encapsulates the entire depth of our reality; by no means am I a nihilist. When first encountering the absurdity of this life I lived, death depressed me. I spent many nights in darkness, staring at my thoughts through the grains of light my pupils drew. Something outside me explained that a start requires an end. If love was invented as a biological response to preservation, then it would never exist without death. And it is quite difficult to feel insignificant during this critical point of universal history.